



participate in many of her recordings, including the Balaji Pancharatna and several others.

These experiences shaped him in various ways. The ability to rebound from setbacks is a valuable skill, both in art and life. Performing arts, like music and sports, instill this resilience and elegance in the face of challenges. “Art-integrated learning has been instrumental in my journey, offering valuable life lessons and creativity,” he agrees.

Stepping into the professional arena

Following his BTech, Prof. Kamakoti performed exceptionally well in the GATE examination, securing admission offers from both IIT Kanpur and IIT Madras. Driven by his passion for research and a desire to contribute to the field, he chose to remain in Chennai and continued his academic journey with an MS (by research) and PhD at the Department of Computer Science and Engineering, IIT Madras. In 1994, he was awarded a PhD degree. His specialisations include graph theory, computational geometry, computer architecture, information security, and VLSI design.

Before joining the faculty at his alma mater, Prof. Kamakoti completed two post-doctoral assignments—one at the Supercomputer Education and Research Center, Indian Institute of Science, Bengaluru, and the other at the Institute of Mathematical Sciences, Chennai. He fondly remembers this period, saying, “During this time, I had the opportunity to interact with accomplished individuals, thanks to my father, who was a highly respected Indian logician, Vedantic scholar, and philosopher. He served as a professor and headed the Department of Sanskrit at the University of Madras, and his ex-



With his students on the day of completing a course

tensive network included prominent teachers and thought leaders.

He got married in 1997. His wife, who came from a family with a strong educational background, shared his commitment to education. Her family had founded a school in 1960 that catered to around 600 rural children, while Prof. Kamakoti’s great-grandfather established a school in 1914 that had over 1200 students. Today, their family continues to mentor schools that provide education to thousands of children below the poverty line, a mission they are deeply committed to.

The marriage between Prof. Kamakoti and his wife was not just a union of two individuals but a fusion of their families’ legacies in education. This shared commitment to education became even more significant in the years that followed when Prof. Kamakoti took on the role of director at the school. He aimed to provide high-quality education to children from rural backgrounds without compromising on admission standards, a mission he continues to pursue.

In 1998, Prof. Kamakoti and his wife welcomed their daughter into the world on Saraswati Puja day, and they named her Bharathi, another name of Saraswati—the Hindu Goddess of knowledge, wisdom, music, arts, and learning.

Prof. Kamakoti’s professional

journey continued to evolve. He moved back to Chennai to be closer to his parents and took up a postdoctoral position at the Institute of Mathematical Sciences (IMSc). During this time, he was engaged in theoretical computer science research, publishing extensively, and gaining valuable insights. He also set up a small supercomputer

cluster at IMSc, which provided him with practical experience in building and maintaining such systems.

This period marked a transition in his career when he received a job offer from ATI Technologies, a Silicon Valley company setting up an office in Chennai. He recalls, “Initially, they offered me a 10x increase from my previous salary. It was a generous package.”

After joining the company, he was responsible for forming a group of pre- and post-silicon processor verification and testing. Setting up the company’s office in Chennai was not without its challenges, including administrative and logistical issues. However, with his Chennai roots and connections, the team managed to overcome these hurdles.

Exploring the path of an academician

At this point, Prof. Kamakoti received offers from both the Indian Institute of Science and IIT Madras. Ultimately, he decided to join IIT Madras. It was a difficult decision for him as he shares, “On one side was my current job, paying around ₹200,000 per month, and on the other, an assistant professor position offering ₹21,000 a month. During this period, my Guruji was not present, but his teachings had instilled in me a sense of clarity and purpose. I am grateful for my wife’s support. She managed